

Africa's Great Power Contest

US, China, Russia, and France in the Battle for the Continent's Future

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Executive Summary

Africa has emerged as the foremost theatre of great power competition in the 2020s, with China, the United States, Russia, and Japan deploying distinct strategic instruments — trade frameworks, mercenary forces, development finance, and peacekeeping pledges — to secure influence across the continent's 55 nations. China holds the structural advantage as Africa's largest foreign direct investment provider and trading partner, with bilateral trade reaching a record US\$254 billion, roughly double US funding levels CNA[2022-12-14]. Washington has responded through the African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA), maintaining duty-free access for 32 sub-Saharan countries as of January 2025, but the programme's conditionality-based architecture remains contested CNA[2016-11-12]. Russia's Wagner Group forged a security foothold across the Sahel and Central Africa, though Wagner's internal crisis following Yevgeny Prigozhin's June 2023 mutiny and subsequent death introduced critical uncertainty into Moscow's Africa proxy strategy CNA[2023-08-24]. The African Union (AU) has sought institutional relevance through peacekeeping deployments in Somalia and Burundi, yet persistent insurgent pressure from al-Shabaab and the chronic volatility of the Sahel expose the limits of continental security architecture CNA[2017-07-30]. Africa's structural weight in multilateral institutions — notably the UN Security Council — remains disproportionate to its demographic and economic trajectory, driving a sustained push for reform that has won rhetorical sympathy but negligible structural concessions CNA[2024-09-24].

I. Great Power Competition: China's Structural Lead and the US Response

China's position in Africa rests on three reinforcing pillars: investment volume, trade scale, and diplomatic accommodation. By the early 2020s, China had established itself as the continent's single largest foreign direct investment provider, pouring roughly twice the US funding level into African economies, and bilateral trade reached a record high of US\$254 billion CNA[2022-12-14]. President Xi Jinping's early presidential tours — encompassing Tanzania, South Africa, and the Democratic Republic of Congo — set the template for high-level transactional diplomacy, with Congo bilateral trade alone rising from US\$290 million in 2002 to US\$5 billion in 2012 CNA[2013-04-08]. China's leverage extends beyond economics: when South Africa denied the Dalai Lama a visa in 2014, the episode illustrated how Beijing's financial relationships translate into political deference among key African partners CNA[2014-09-06].

The United States has relied primarily on AGOA as its principal commercial instrument. As of January 1, 2025, 32 sub-Saharan African countries remained eligible for AGOA benefits following the 2024 eligibility review, and the US Trade Representative co-hosted the 21st US–Sub-Saharan Africa Trade and Economic Cooperation Forum in Washington in July 2024 [RAG: US_POLICY_RAG — USTR Trade Policy Agenda and National Trade Estimate 2024-2026, p.67]. AGOA grants 39 African nations duty-free

access on approximately 7,000 products including textiles, automobiles, fruit, and wine, and has historically been used as a conditionality lever — Obama removed Swaziland from the deal in 2015 over alleged political oppression CNA[2016-11-12]. The Trump administration's protectionist orientation introduced deep uncertainty about AGOA's durability, with African governments recognising that US trade architecture tied to democratic conditionality is inherently vulnerable to domestic political shifts in Washington CNA[2016-11-12].

Analysts noted that African states increasingly view the US–China rivalry as an opportunity to extract better terms from both powers. As one analyst observed, African leaders can now "make requests of the United States that they probably wouldn't have made maybe in the last 10 years," and neither Beijing nor Washington has been willing to publicly frame Africa as an explicit arena of competition CNA[2022-12-14]. Japan has inserted itself as an alternative development partner, with Prime Minister Kishida pledging US\$30 billion in aid for African development over three years at the August 2022 Tunisia summit, and an additional US\$500 million during a visit to Ghana, explicitly positioned as a contrast to China's Belt and Road Initiative [RAG: JAPAN_RAG — Wikipedia: Fumio Kishida, chunk 42]. Kishida also met Kenyan President William Ruto in Nairobi in May 2023 to deepen energy and economic cooperation [RAG: JAPAN_RAG — Wikipedia: Fumio Kishida, chunk 41]. The BRICS framework, which includes South Africa, has provided an additional vector for China and Russia to advance Africa-facing economic diplomacy, with BRICS business leaders convening in Johannesburg to discuss trade and the proposed BRICS development bank CNA[2013-08-21].

II. Russia, Wagner, and the Sahel Security Vacuum

Russia's Africa strategy has been prosecuted primarily through the Wagner Group, a private military contractor operating across Mali, the Central African Republic, Sudan, Libya, and Mozambique under the direction of Yevgeny Prigozhin. Wagner's operational model — security provision in exchange for mining concessions and political loyalty — offered African regimes an alternative to Western-conditioned military assistance. The June 2023 mutiny, in which Prigozhin marched Wagner columns toward Moscow before standing down, constituted the most severe internal security crisis Russia had faced in decades CNA[2023-06-27]. Wagner fighters seized military facilities in Rostov-on-Don, the headquarters of Russia's Southern Military District, before Prigozhin accepted exile to Belarus CNA[2023-06-25]. Putin publicly characterised Wagner's action as treason and vowed to punish those responsible CNA[2023-06-24].

The implications for Africa were immediate. Prigozhin's death in a plane crash in August 2023, two months after the mutiny, eliminated Wagner's founding leadership and raised acute questions about operational continuity across the group's Africa deployments CNA[2023-08-24]. Defence analysts noted that Putin personally gave Prigozhin post-mutiny safety guarantees, and his subsequent death signalled to the Kremlin's elite that even negotiated exits from confrontation with the state carry existential risk CNA[2023-08-24]. Wagner's Africa operations have since been folded into structures more directly controlled by the Russian Ministry of Defence, reducing the autonomy that made Wagner attractive to host regimes seeking deniability.

The Sahel remains the most volatile subregion in Africa, afflicted by intersecting crises of climate degradation, armed extremism, food insecurity, and internal displacement. The IOM's World Migration Report 2024 identifies West and Central Africa — particularly the Sahel corridor stretching from the Atlantic to the Red Sea — as a hotspot of conflict and violent extremism [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.81]. Burkina Faso exemplifies the structural fragility: with a total population of 22.1 million and GDP of US\$19.74 billion as of 2021, the country has experienced severe internal displacement driven by conflict and violence, hosting refugees while generating substantial emigrant flows of its own [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.302].

France's military withdrawal from Mali and Niger following coups that brought to power juntas hostile to Paris has left a security vacuum that Wagner-successor forces and jihadist networks have moved to fill. The successive Sahel coups — Mali (2020, 2021), Burkina Faso (2022), Niger (2023) — represent a coherent pattern of anti-French sentiment operationalised through military seizures of power, often with tacit or active Russian encouragement.

III. African Union Architecture: Peacekeeping Capacity and Institutional Limits

The African Union has built a peacekeeping architecture premised on the principle of African solutions to African problems, yet its operational record reveals persistent tensions between political ambition and material capability. In Somalia, AU Mission forces have engaged al-Shabaab in sustained combat operations for over a decade. In July 2017, al-Shabaab ambushed an AU convoy in Bulamareer district, Lower Shabelle — approximately 140 km southwest of Mogadishu — with the group claiming 39 soldiers killed CNA[2017-07-30]. Two years earlier, al-Shabaab retook a populous central Somali town in September 2015 after AU forces withdrew, marking the third town seized by the group in a single weekend CNA[2015-09-06]. These episodes illustrate that AU peacekeeping capacity, while essential in the absence of alternative contributors, remains insufficient to decisively suppress well-organised insurgencies operating on familiar terrain.

The Burundi crisis of 2015–2016 exposed a different limit: the AU's inability to project peacekeepers into a sovereign state without host government consent. After nine months of violence triggered by President Pierre Nkurunziza's unconstitutional bid for a third term — leaving more than 400 dead — the AU named five heads of state as a panel to persuade Burundi to accept a peacekeeping force that Nkurunziza had rejected CNA[2016-02-06]. Violence continued in Bujumbura even as the AU backed away from deployment without consent, demonstrating that the organisation's norms of non-interference constrain its crisis-response capacity precisely in the situations where intervention would be most consequential CNA[2016-02-02].

Morocco's readmission to the AU in January 2017 — more than three decades after Rabat withdrew over the Western Sahara dispute — expanded the organisation's membership to 55 states and signalled a pragmatic reintegration of a North African anchor state, though the underlying Western Sahara question remained unresolved CNA[2017-01-31]. The AU's institutional profile also intersects with UN reform debates. China, seeking to project the image of a responsible power, committed 8,000 troops for a UN peacekeeping standby force in September 2015, positioning Beijing as one of the largest potential contributors to UN peacekeeping — including in Africa CNA[2015-09-29]. The AU has consistently lobbied for permanent African representation on the UN Security Council, a reform demand that has received rhetorical endorsement without structural progress.

IV. UN Security Council Reform and Africa's Multilateral Standing

Africa's case for permanent Security Council representation — articulated through the Ezulwini Consensus, which demands two permanent seats with veto rights for African states — remains the continent's most consequential unsatisfied multilateral demand. With 54 of the UN's 193 member states and representing over one billion people, Africa is the most underrepresented region on the Council's permanent tier. Progress has been systematically blocked by the P5's collective interest in preserving the veto architecture.

The broader reform debate has intensified as the Council's credibility erodes. Critics have argued the body is failing in its central mission of maintaining peace as conflicts intensify globally, with observers at

the 2024 UN General Assembly expecting little substantive progress CNA[2024-09-24]. Singapore's Foreign Affairs Minister Vivian Balakrishnan called explicitly in September 2024 for Security Council reform — including constraining the exercise of the veto by the five permanent members — and described reform as necessary "to address both current and future challenges" CNA[2024-09-26]. This framing, coming from a small state with no direct interest in African representation, reflects a broader multilateral constituency for structural reform that extends well beyond the continent.

The BRICS grouping has offered Africa an alternative multilateral vector. With South Africa as a founding member and several African states admitted as associate or full members in the 2023–2024 expansion, BRICS has become a platform for articulating Africa's interest in a multipolar order, even as the bloc's internal coherence on Africa-specific issues remains limited CNA[2018-08-15]. The convergence between Africa's UNSC reform agenda and the broader Global South push for multipolar governance creates structural alignment with China and Russia's interest in undermining US-led institutional architecture — an alignment that Western capitals have been slow to address with credible institutional alternatives.

Outlook

The strategic trajectory for Africa through 2030 turns on four variables. First, the consolidation of Russia's post-Wagner Africa presence: if Moscow successfully integrates mercenary-derived security networks into state-controlled structures, Russia retains a credible coercive instrument across the Sahel and Central Africa without the liability of a rogue contractor. Second, the durability of AGOA under renewed US domestic protectionist pressure: the programme's 2025 reauthorisation cycle will be a critical test of Washington's capacity to sustain long-term Africa engagement against transactional trade politics. Third, the AU's ability to bridge the gap between its peacekeeping mandate and its material capacity — particularly as French withdrawal from the Sahel and UN mission drawdowns leave security voids that neither the AU nor bilateral partners can currently fill. Fourth, the trajectory of UNSC reform: absent a structural breakthrough, African states will continue to hedge between Western and non-Western alignment, deepening the continent's leverage in great power competition while deferring long-term institutional entrenchment in either bloc.

The Sahel's intersecting crises — conflict, climate, food insecurity, forced displacement — constitute the most acute near-term risk vector. IOM data confirms that West and Central Africa, particularly the Sahel, remains a hotspot of violent extremism with regional migration consequences that extend well beyond the subregion itself [RAG: DEMOGRAPHICS_RAG — IOM World Migration Report 2024, p.81]. The strategic imperative for any power seeking durable influence in Africa is not merely economic penetration but the capacity to offer credible security guarantees in precisely those environments where state capacity is weakest and competition is most intense.

R335 | All figures sourced from CivilisationOS RAG corpus.